To make matters worse, the government blocked initial attempts by international aid organizations to assist in relief efforts. The government agents in different regions were at times given conflicting orders, further confusing an already chaotic situation. It also was apparent that the authorities did not want aid workers to enter the hardest-hit areas around the Ayeyarwaddy delta. Military roadblocks were setup and access to the delta remained restricted. It should be added that even in the best of times, access to the remote delta areas is problematic. The tatmadaw was also in the process of a generational change and institutional restructuring. This factor may have slowed down the decision-making process down considerably. The timing of the disaster, less than eight months after the Saffron Revolution, led to the military perception to deal with this as a security problem rather than a humanitarian concern. Furthermore, the lack of experts with the necessary technical skills hampered the operational effectiveness.

Internal assistance from citizens was also rejected as the government confiscated supplies and refused most citizens' requests to enter the areas hit. Several arrests were made of private citizens accused of subversive activities for attempting to help in cyclone relief. It was speculated that supplies left with the military never reached the affected areas. Myanmar authorities denied requests from the United States, Britain, and France to deliver supplies to the areas affected. Had the authorities in Myanmar allowed supplies to be transported to the military airport at Bathein, aid would have reached the population much quicker. The international community was also concerned that the death toll could rise due to disease and starvation.

Within days, full-blown condemnation of the regime was airing. Foreign ministers and international dignitaries spoke out against the junta's seeming indifference to the suffering of the population. This rhetoric was for the most part empty because of a guaranteed Chinese veto of any action proposed against Myanmar. This may have actually increased the paranoia levels of the junta in Naypyidaw, leading to even further delays by the authorities. Media access was significantly restricted as the government arrested anyone attempting to provide footage of the affected areas. The junta felt that a sudden influx of foreigners could loosen their grip on power. Monitoring the international aid workers would also be difficult.